Diploma in UX Design

E-commerce: a Pleasant Shopping Experience

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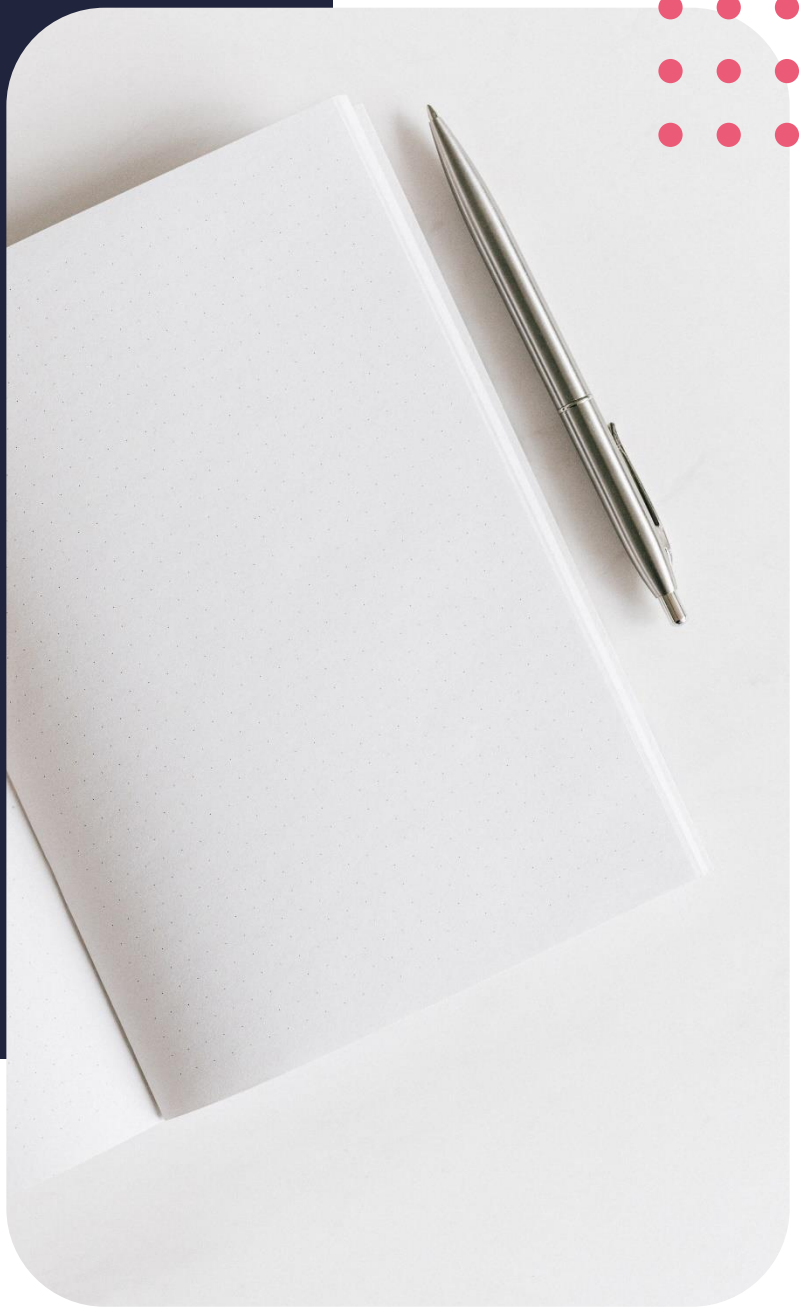


Lesson objectives

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Analyse getting users' attention
- Explore the product range and shortlist the best options
- Review and select the most suitable product

Introduction

One of the most common tasks for User Experience designers is to design online shops or e-commerce apps. Trade is the lifeblood of any economy. As more trade becomes digital, UX designers with e-commerce experience will become more in demand. With the Covid pandemic fast-forwarding a lot of digital technology, the e-commerce industry has become more accessible and effective needing to cater for more customers than ever before.

E-commerce sites must provide a very pleasant user experience, otherwise, their products won't sell. Customers have a large variety of online shopping options, so if there is even a slight usability issue with an online shop, users won't hesitate to take their business to a competitor. Competition in e-commerce is very fierce, and one way to set you or your client's digital shop apart from the rest is to provide an excellent user experience.

In this and the following lesson, you will learn how to design e-commerce apps or websites that are easy to use and provide a pleasant shopping experience. This will also point out why online shoppers prefer one online shop above the other.

Getting users' attention

1. Digital marketing and Search Engine Optimisation (SEO)

First and foremost, a user must become aware or discover your online store. This is not an easy task because there are thousands of stores to choose from. The topic of digital marketing deals with making customers aware of and attract them to your shop.

For a UX designer, it is very important to be aware of the concept of Search Engine Optimisation, abbreviated as 'SEO'. It is about getting your e-commerce store, or its products ranked as high as possible on search engine results pages. SEO is also a specialised subject field and justifies an entire course on its own, therefore, if you are interested, check out our Digital Marketing & SEO course as well.

Improvements in UX will also improve SEO. For example, using appropriate search terms, a readable website URL, good product descriptions, interesting and helpful content and videos about your product or sector, descriptive headings and captions, fast download speed, clear site navigation all contribute to both good UX and good SEO.

Online shoppers are very impatient and will usually click on the very first search result for an online shop, maybe the second, third, or 'above the fold', meaning that your shop must be visible within the screen without scrolling down. Very few users will continue searching beyond the first page of search results.

2. Great first impression, easy to get started and start shopping right away

Once a user has found your online store, allow them to explore the shop, what you have to offer, what its prices are, and shortlisting or wish-listing of products without requiring them to sign up first. Signing up is a strong commitment, and upon first landing, the user is not ready for such a commitment yet.

After you convinced the user through amazing content and product offerings, make signing up quick, easy, and risk-free. You can even allow for guest checkout so that users can buy even without signing in.

Where possible, allow users to start off paying cash, don't force them to give credit card details initially.

Ask for some information from the user initially while signing up. When a user signs up, rather start with just the basic, essential information, then as time goes by, you can ask for more information to build a more complete profile.

Entice users to sign up with a gift or a good discount on their first purchase. This will increase the chances that a visitor will become a buyer.

It is essential to create a great first impression with beautiful design, stunning pictures, and interesting videos. The online shop must be truly eye-catching and must create a professional first impression, otherwise, users may not trust the site. A visually great first impression is essential otherwise many users will abandon it without even exploring what you have to offer, therefore, an e-commerce site must be very easy and intuitive to use; top UX is a must for success.

The user must be able to onboard or sign up and then shop immediately in a single, short session. No waiting should be required. If a user first must wait for approval or some other reason, they will lose interest and shop somewhere else. Instant gratification is key in e-commerce.

3. Quality, trust, and persuasiveness

The e-commerce site or app must convey an image of quality and trust.

Because users can't touch and feel for quality like in a traditional shop, they rely on the online shop to stock only goods that are of the same or better quality as promised and look as appealing as on the picture. If a user gets an impression that quality is questionable, they will not trust the shop. If they did buy and they receive goods of poor quality, chances are that they will never trust you again, unless you have a very favourable return policy, which they trust.

This also explains why product visualising tools and even virtual 'handling' of goods are so important. If you can't touch items like in a real shop, an e-commerce site must provide tools to mimic such actions, like three-dimensional handling, rotating and zooming tools.

The credibility and trust of an e-commerce business, especially if its brand is not yet well established, can be established through a physical presence like branded delivery vehicles, branded warehouses, and collection points like Takealot. Apart from creating trust, it also increases brand awareness and serves as advertising for the online shop.

Persuasiveness is key to success in e-commerce. Competitive platforms make ethical (therefore sustainable) use of persuasion techniques, consumer behaviour and behavioural economics principles. A whole lesson will be devoted to online persuasiveness or techniques you can use to persuade your site visitors to make purchase decisions.

4. Reasonable pricing and specials

Lower prices are expected for certain basic goods. Many users, especially in a developing country context and for certain product categories, expect to pay lower prices online compared to prices in brick-and-mortar shops because they reason its riskier for them to shop online, and they expect the retailer to save costs because they don't have to pay for a physical shop's rent and up-keeping.

However, for some other types of goods paying more on online channels are perfectly fine or at least tolerated because a product bought directly from the factory's e-commerce site is perceived as more trustworthy than a 3rd party seller's site, especially in case the manufacturer is a well-known brand.

Another reason why customers may be willing to pay higher prices online is if the brand is perceived as prestigious or luxury, or if the goods are something highly specialised, unique, or scarce.

The last important reason why customers may be willing to pay more online is convenience. Customers are generally willing to pay extra in case it is easy to shop from their home or while on the go on a mobile device if they don't have to wait long and the goods will be delivered straight to where they will need it. Convenience is an important factor of success in e-commerce.

Price promotions, specials, bargains, and loyalty programmes are essential to improve the perceived user experience on an e-commerce site or app and to entice more people to buy from you. A gift or voucher for signing up may go a long way to persuade people to start buying from you. Pricing and specials immediately attract attention and retain regular customer engagement because it gives you a reason to regularly communicate with your potential customers without bothering them in case your offers are appealing to them. It also provides customers with a reason to be on the lookout for messages from you and to visit your online store regularly, checking in for any interesting bargains. Regular specials and being rewarded for buying regularly are essential to create frequent visits to the store, to facilitate habit buying and to create brand loyalty. A loyalty programme may be very powerful to keep customers coming back and to increase sales per customer.

Overall, variability in reward is important for customer engagement, to keep your specials interesting. Bargains must appear regularly but not quite daily, just regularly enough to keep customers interested. These promotions must pop up in unpredictable intervals, otherwise, customers may lose interest as it becomes less surprising and less exciting.

Having said all this regarding promotions, there are also risks involved. Firstly, a promotion may be very expensive and unprofitable. Some customer segments find hunting for bargains exceptionally exciting, and it keeps them checking in daily. However, some of these bargain-hunting customers may suck the profit from an e-commerce store, therefore it's important to design your incentive scheme in such a manner to prevent abuse and only attract potentially profitable customers, considering their long-term profitability. The second important caution against some forms of bargains is that they may not lead to true customer loyalty. The moment you don't offer these types of specials, many customers will simply stop buying from you.

Did you know?

Did you know that developers end up spending around 50% of their time fixing issues due to poor user experience? This can be avoided with better planning.

Explore the product range and shortlist the best options

Wide supplier choice and product range

Ideally, an e-commerce store should have a wide range of product choices within the product category they specialise in. For example, if you sell sports shoes, sell a large variety of sports shoes.

Also, offer a variety of complementary products or products that are generally used together. Apart from generating more income from such cross-sell opportunities, such products can be bundled and dispatched together for the buyer's

convenience. Users don't want to pay twice for delivery or go through the product checkout process twice on different online shops, rather they want it all under one digital roof.

Because e-commerce stores don't have to stock every item in each branch, like often the case is for physical stores, it is possible and desirable from the customer's perspective, for e-commerce sites to stock specialised, niche or long-tail products. These are products that are not fast sellers, some may rarely sell. But it's the very presence of such a variety that motivates many customers to use a particular e-commerce store. This creates niche market opportunities for unique products, not found somewhere else. It can be a great opportunity to compete with large, well-established e-commerce stores.

Peer-to-peer sales, auctions, and second-hand goods

An e-commerce site can also consider establishing a peer-to-peer selling platform, or a second-hand goods and auctions platform, where not only new but also second-hand goods of the product categories can be sold. This blows extra life into the platform as more people can interact. It will include more price-sensitive customers and attract the regular attention of bargain hunters. Users may also be more willing to buy new goods from the online shop because they know that if they don't need that item anymore, they can also sell it there and make some money back.

Help to discover and shortlist product possibilities

By now your users have found your e-commerce store and realised you possibly may have the right type or category of product for them. Now they must be assisted to search for a product that will meet their needs. Initially a user would like to shortlist just a few, like two or three, possibly as many as five, possible product options. To shortlist a few options from your store's large inventory, search and filter functionality is needed.

Most users use the search bar to locate products, therefore the search bar must be quite large and placed where users expect it, which is normally near the top of the page. To enhance the search bar, use a white or very light search bar, with a significantly darker background. Add a search icon like a magnifying glass or another type of icon your target users associate with the term search.

Provide a suggestions list below the search bar as the user types but make certain to accommodate common spelling mistakes so that the users don't have to remember the exact wording or be penalised for a spelling mistake. An intelligent search algorithm that considers misspelling, common ways to describe, text mining beyond product names or headings (includes deep product descriptions) is needed. Intelligent interpretation of the search query is important allowing users to make spelling mistakes, misconceptions, or use synonyms. Otherwise, inappropriate or no search results will be returned.

Add autocomplete functionality in the search bar, to prevent the user from typing the whole word or phrase. This will save the user time, effort and may guide the user in case they only vaguely know what to type.

Enable search by a variety of concepts, including brand, product type or category, theme, user need, also non-product related searches e.g., contact detail, delivery options, tracking, payment, returns etc.

Add advanced search functionality with filters suitable for different groups of users with different needs, including advanced users. Advanced users know very well what product features they are interested in and will appreciate more advanced and detailed search filters.

A search bar alone is usually not enough. Some users want to navigate through product categories or directory-like listings. Therefore, use a combination of search by classified categories, like the old search engines from the 1990s where the user navigates through different categories. A very common, effective design pattern is to have a search bar on top and a product category on the left sidebar, like in Amazon.

Search results lists and recommender systems

After a user initiated a search through a search box and possibly applied some search filter to it, the search results must be presented as a user-friendly search results list. To be user friendly consider the following:

- Results must be ordered in descending order of appropriateness, with the most appealing products to the user at the top.
- Add filter and order functionality so that the user can shorten the search result list by applying search filters targeting important product features.
- Add sorting ability to enable the user to sort the result by features most important to them. This may be incorporated in some search algorithms where a single selected feature may carry more weight so that it can be ordered higher on the list. Alternatively, it can be a complex multi-sport where the user specifies what features are most important, the second most important and so on.
- Support infinite scroll rather than many pages with just a small number of listings per page where the user repeatedly has to tap on the "Next" button.
- However, if you decide for some reason not to provide an infinite scrollable, consider the following:
    - Some users prefer to specify the number of items listed per page, for example, some users who don't want to feel overwhelmed but also who are not very picky about what option to choose may prefer to be only presented with say five or ten results per page. Others may prefer maybe fifty or even infinite scroll.
    - After the user tapped on 'Next', place focus on the top part of the next page's list, not at the bottom. Some websites dump you on the bottom of the next page's list after you've clicked 'Next' on the previous page. This creates confusion about where the user is, and it forces the user to scroll to the top to continue the search process.
    - 'Next' and 'Previous' page links should appear both at the top and bottom of a search result list page. Users tend to move back and forth between search results pages, and they may want to go forward whether they are at the bottom or top of the page. Sometimes they want to skip several pages and don't want to scroll all the way up or down just to press the 'Back' or 'Next' button. What is especially annoying and unintuitive is if back or forward buttons are only at the top, which forces a user to scroll to the top after they worked their way down the results list, so that they can move on to the next page.
- Support seamless infinite scroll which brings users right back to the place in the list where they were after viewing a product's details page. Never let users must start scrolling again from the top of the list every time they return to the list. Even some well-known e-commerce and social media giants have this issue, which greatly reduces the user experience.
- Each search result listing must contain just enough information to avoid cluttering but to inform the user whether it's worth clicking into the details page for that listed product. Users want to quickly scan the search result list of product summaries, where the summary just contain the information, they are interested in. This can be aided by search filters as well but avoid a situation where the user must tap away from the list into a product details page, just to get some crucial information as this slows down and disrupts the user's flow. A very common usability issue in e-commerce sites is product listings that are so minimal that a user doesn't get basic feature information at first glance.

In addition to a search bar and product category listings, a recommender system making accurate, personalised suggestions for complementary or similar products is essential to help the user to make better product decisions. It also aids to upsell or cross-sell more products. A recommender system is simply an automated system that displays different product options along with search results, or even before a user started to initiate a search. A recommender system must act as a good salesperson, making expert recommendations based on the user's needs.

- A recommender system can be of the machine-learning type, which is automated, and learn preferences from specific and similar users.

- Alternatively, a recommender system can be of an online survey or expert system type, where the user is asked a few questions. The system automatically recommends the most suitable product or shortlist of products that will meet the user's needs.

As an alternative to a large list of possible products in descending order of appropriateness, present a shortlist of just a few, most appropriate products to the user. Fine balance must be reached between too limited choices which could make the user feel disempowered from making a good choice or an information overload that leads to analysis paralysis. Both too little and too many choices can cause quick customer abandonment of the e-commerce site. As a rough rule of thumb, between three to ten, products may be shortlisted.

What is very important to improve the user experience on an e-commerce site is the ability to mark products for deeper or later consideration, which can be in the form of a simple wishlist or even a comparison table.

Review and select the most suitable product

Describing and comparing the product

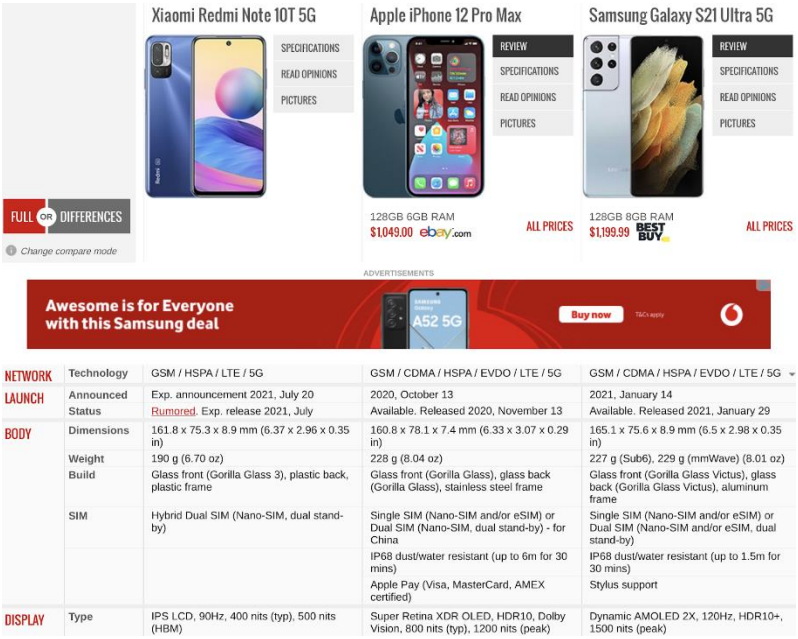
Useful product description, visualisation and content on products are essential. Focus on all key product selection features, it is those features that users generally consider when selecting a product. In most cases price is the most important product selection criterion, therefore price must be clearly visible. In rare branding situations, it may be considered not to display price, especially for luxury goods where 'price is not a problem', or in case the product or more commonly a service is so customisable that quoting a price is not easy. However, many customers won't even bother contacting you to ask about pricing if a price is not specified, especially if your industry is very competitive and the user can easily find something else. Other common product features that need to be properly described may include size, capacity or weight, availability in case it's not immediately available, colour, brand, rating, and any other important features that distinguish a product.

Brand positioning is the way the product is positioned or placed in the mind of the customer relative to other products or brands. It is an important consideration in product descriptions and search filtering. This is closely related to the product and brand's Unique Selling Proposition (USP): What makes this product both different and better than another option? Why would a customer choose this product instead of another? This Unique Selling Proposition of the brand and individual product must stand out and be summarised in the product listing of which can be elaborated on the product's details page.

Clearly explain and illustrate the benefits of features and differences between features. Some features can be too complex for users to understand, therefore explain the benefits of those features. This is a screengrab of a short video on the GoPro website that illustrates the benefit of the 'Hyper MaxSmooth' feature. Although the added stability to the video can't be display so well on this still screengrab, the smoothness and improved video quality that it provides can be seen on the video. This points out how important video can be to illustrate the benefits of features on e-commerce sites.

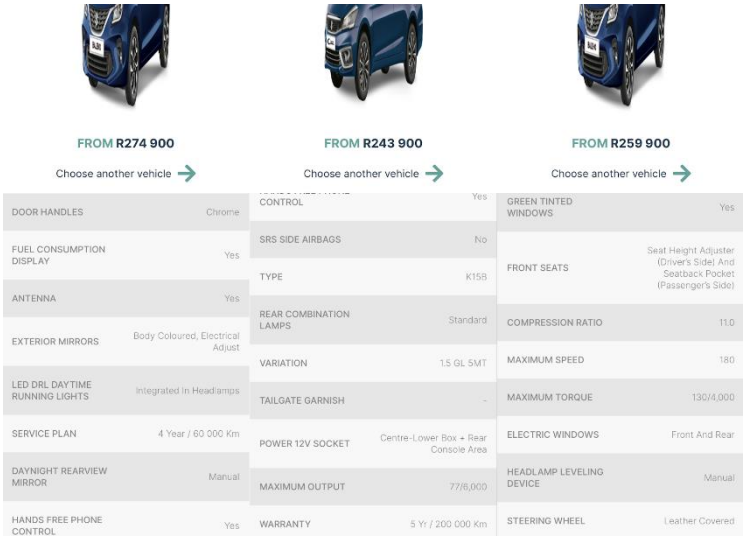
Do not oversimplify product descriptions too much. For savvy users who know what they want it is a huge irritation because they must look specifications up on the internet, and as soon as you make things difficult, you take a risk losing them. Even non-savvy customers who don't know what they want should at least to some degree be assisted in finding a product that matches their needs best. As an example, a recent trend in cellphone retailer brochures is to oversimplify product listings to such a degree that the user must rely on looks and price only to make a decision. Like in this example, the user has no way to spot the differences between the phones except price and appearance. There is also no attempt to help them make an informed decision.

Fortunately for the savvy user, there are sites like gmsarena.com which specialises in making phone comparisons easy with excellent product comparison functionalities. The problem this creates for the original e-commerce site is that it might lose the customer to a competitor's site. Clever competitors know that people visiting comparison sites are in the market for this type of product, so they place their adverts there. Here you can see an example of a competitor's advert clearly displayed in the middle of the screen. If the competitor can offer a better deal, the original site almost certainly will lose the sale.



Product comparison tables can be very effective to compare shortlisted products head-on. Apple Store and GMSArena let users easily compare phones directly with one another through comparison tables as illustrated above, which is essential for both people who know what they want and those who have no idea how to choose. What is important for comparison tables is to align the features below each other in rows, or next to each other in columns. If the user scrolls up or down the table, the compared product rows must move alongside each other.

Avoid misalignment as you can see in this example of a car comparison table on Suzuki's website. Another mistake that this site makes is that the features are listed randomly, not logically grouped. This makes scrolling and comparing very difficult.

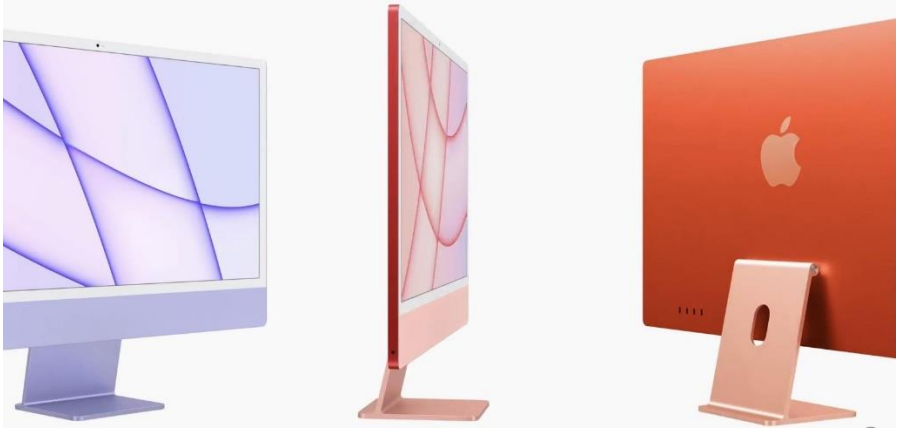


Keeping things simple is good but keep the wise words of Einstein in mind: "Everything should be made as simple as possible, but no simpler". The recent design trend to oversimplify things is in many cases a mistake. Also, not all users prefer things oversimplified. A fairly large proportion of the population are analytical as opposed to intuitive or feeling orientated, and they tend to have more buying power and decision-making authority, so do not ignore them.

Vividly visualising the product

Detailed product descriptions are important to make an online product tangible so that the user can understand the product even without touching it. Because users can't touch and handle products and services, at least provide tools and other mechanisms to experience it as far as they virtually can. Clear, professional-quality pictures from different angles, and even product videos, are important to make a product vivid and easy to assess virtually.

The following is a good example of a short video-like animation from the Apple store that displays an iMac from different angles, all in a single animation. This gives the user a good idea of how the product looks like in three dimensions.



In addition to automated video animations, a user can be empowered to rotate or handle the product themselves, using gestures on the e-commerce app or website. This creates the perception of inspecting or 'trying out', even though it is virtual. Here is a good example from the Apple website of how a user can use the drag gesture to rotate an iMac.

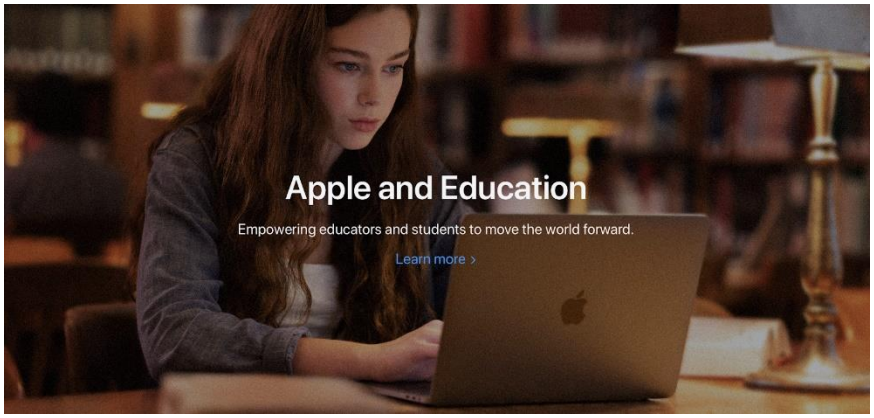
It is important to illustrate through beautiful pictures and videos how the product can be used in real life. This will give the user an idea of how it can further improve their lives, how it can address their needs and help them imagine using the product. Here you can see an example of a product from a sport apparel shop's site that shows the use and function of a product. If the picture did not feature the model, the product might have been skimmed over quickly after a brief misperception that it might be some form of camping gear.

HS Fitness Weighted Sandbag 10kg

GoFit Elevated Chin-Up Station

Place special attention on the angles from the user's perspective, for example, if your product is food, picture it from the angle of the table where the user would sit, or from the driver's seat in case of a car. This assist in aiding the user on how to use the product. Here is a good example of a video clip illustrating a product being used from the user's perspective: a surfer riding a wave using the GoPro. It is now very easy for the user to imagine using and benefitting from the product which increases chances for making a sale.

For products that a user may wish to buy to get attention or to gain social status, like a beautiful dress, luxury watch or a nice car, also focus on angles from which other people will see the user wearing, driving or using the product. For example, show a luxury car with the driver visible from a bystander's perspective, or a user speaking on a stylish phone photographed from the view of someone next to the user. Here is a good example from the Apple website of a good photo angle focusing on a user using a high-status product. A user searching for a laptop, to whom social status is important, will easily be able to imagine the social status she may gain by others seeing her working on the laptop where the iconic Apple logo is visible to others in the room.



However, product descriptions are not enough. Provide interesting and useful content, such as product comparisons, reviews, how-to setup or use the product, through vividly descriptive videos and articles, and possibly podcasts. Videos are particularly important because more and more users prefer to use video sharing sites such as YouTube as an information search and learning tool.

Product reviews

Product reviews and ratings by fellow users, influencers or by the platform itself, can add a lot of value to the e-commerce user experience. Fellow user reviews are often more credible to customers than the official product description; users trust other user's opinions more than marketing messages. User comments also address real user needs and concerns that the seller may not have thought of.

Ratings of products allow for quick and easy product selection. Ratings are useful for products and especially services which quality is difficult or subjective to assess. Ratings are important for users who don't want to take risks or who looks at others' actions to make their own decisions. This is a large part of the population that we will learn in a future course more about.

Some online stores are viewed as opinion leaders in their industry if they appoint a panel or a single specialist to write an official review of a product. This may let your site become the go-to authority on a product category, especially if you operate in a niche market or highly specialised industry.

Upselling and cross-selling

After you assisted the user to find the desired, suggest other products that may benefit them as well. It may be an upgraded or more luxury version of the product, or additional features or benefits. This is known as trading up or upselling. For example, if you want to lease a car, car rental websites are eager to offer you a larger car or better insurance cover protection against a larger range of unfortunate happenings.

You may also suggest a complementary product that is often used together with the chosen product. This is known as cross-selling. For example, Amazon Books often suggest books on the same topic that other users tend to buy together.

However, do not let the user feel being pushed into the more expensive option as this might cause brand reputation damage. Even worse is to trick people into opting in for additional features sneaked into the checkout process. For

example, if you want to buy a domain name for your website, GoDaddy automatically add extra, often very expensive domain names, and the responsibility lies with the customer to notice the addition of these add-ons. Users should not feel that they must be on the checkout for tricks used against them. This is an example of the use of ‘dark UX patterns’ which are unethical, brand-damaging, bad for customer retention, and will be covered in a future lesson.

Conclusion

In this lesson, we’ve learned how important UX is in the e-commerce world. An online store must be very user-friendly otherwise users will simply switch to another store in the highly competitive space of e-commerce.

We learned about the importance of being discoverable – users must know about your e-commerce store and the products you have to offer. You must make it clear what you offer, and you must stock the type of products your target market is interested in.

We also learned how important it is to help the customer to find the right product in your inventory. Users get easily overwhelmed with too many choices and too little help to make a good decision.

In the next lesson, we will continue our discovery of UX best practices for e-commerce sites and apps. We will continue the user’s online shopping journey from where we left off in this lesson. After the user selected the right product, it must be very easy to pay for it and to get it delivered. You must also provide excellent after-sales support, and keep the user engaged for future purchases. These will be discovered next.

Steve Krug, a user experience professional and author of “Don’t make me think’ believes that “usability is about people and how they understand and use things, not about technology’. The human psychological aspect behind UX design is of equally importance. If your design looks and reacts amazing but does not satisfy your user’s experience, you need to rethink your design.